



# MOORS

## CIRCLING THE SAHARA

SAHARAN MAURITANIA HAS ONE OF THE LOWEST population densities in the world, with eight persons per square mile (three per square km). Less than 50 years ago nomadism was practiced by almost all Mauriticians, but today the Moors are one of the

### The nomadic year

The Moors spend October to December in the north of their territory where there are few wells, but excellent grazing.

As winter ends they move south through dunes and dusty plains.

There is little movement between June and September, but after the fall rains the Moors trek every day to return to the northern pastures.

### THE RHAL

Every family owns a *rhal*, a wooden platform with carved legs. When the family is on the move the *rhal* is placed upside down on a camel. Cooking pots and containers are hung from its sides, and the women and children sit on it, like a saddle. The *rhal* is the woman's responsibility and, like all her possessions, is kept on the northern side of the tent.



### PACKING UP THE CAMP

It only takes the women an hour or two to dismantle the tents for loading onto the camels. Once the tent components and other possessions are piled on board, the women are helped up and the children handed to them. Men walk behind the camels with the cattle. There is no definite destination for the next camp—the men stop when they see an appropriate spot.



Curved wooden tent poles.

Head coverings protect people from the sun, wind, and sand.

